Bavadra; Jabir Singh, a lawyer; Bob Kumar, a Fijian politician; and Harish Sharma, who served for about a month as deputy prime minister of Fiji, had been picked up by the Fijian army along with other politicians and prominent figures. 'Our informer in Australia got in touch with human right groups to galvanise international pressure for their release,' he said.

In mid-September, fearing that some of his aides might attempt to reinstate democracy, Rabuka declared Fiji a republic. He took power away from all those he suspected of turning against him and installed Kamisese Mara as prime minister and Ratu Penaia Ganilau as president. Since these two were selected, not elected, actual power remained with Rabuka.

In early October 1987, Rabuka severed Fiji's ties with the UK, claiming in public meetings that he had no political ambition and his efforts were mainly focused on restoring Fijian culture and the Fijian way of life that had been threatened by the outsider Indians.

India's minister of state for external affairs, K. Natwar Singh, had been attending the United Nations General Assembly at the time of the Fijian crisis. Rajiv Gandhi asked him to make a statement on Fiji. In his address to the global community, Singh said: 'Attempts to deprive citizens of the country of their legitimate rights merely on the basis of their racial origin are against all tenets of democracy and human rights and are contrary to the UN charter. What is happening in Fiji has distinct and unacceptable racial overtones. This development is reprehensible. We believe that the path to peace and prosperity in Fiji lies in restoration of democracy and the rule of law.'

The Rajiv Gandhi regime refused to recognise Rabuka's military government and even warned him against depriving a majority